

SPIN-OFFS

Social Science

**The Aam Activist**

The common man who has transformed himself from an ordinary to an extraor-

dinary crusader of citizen's rights.

Candlelight Vigils

Earlier used to express nostalgia at the Wagah border. Now, a sign of solidarity for the causes that need attention, every vigil has been widely covered,

hotly debated, generated awareness and got the government to act.

Online Campaigns All you needed to do was sign your name at the end of the chain mail and declare yourself a thoughtful citizen. The more the merrier.

Jaago Re The most successful TV and media-based public consciousness campaign launched by Bangalore-based NGO Janaagraha with the support of Tata Tea, it addresses the youth against social ills such as corruption.

THE CONSCIENCE KEEPERS

SABRINA LALL Sister of Jessica, who was murdered by Manu Sharma, son of a powerful politician Vinod Sharma, at a pub in Delhi in 1999. Sharma was acquitted in 2006 after which Sabrina mobilised public ire leading to his conviction by Delhi High Court.

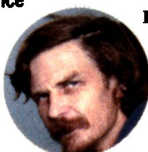
NEELAM KATARA Her son Nitish was murdered in 2002 by Vikas Yadav, son of an influential politician, and his cousin Vishal. The case dragged on for six years and over 400 hearings. In 2008, a fast-track court gave life terms to both.



ARVIND KEJRIWAL A social activist and crusader for greater transparency in all walks of life, he was instrumental in implementing the Right to Information Act which equips individual citizens with the power to question their government.

ARUNA ROY AND JEAN DREZE Social activist Roy and economist Dreze were part of Sonia Gandhi's National Advisory Committee that helped draft the RTI and the NREGA. They have since

then become the conscience keepers of the government.



so much about the suffering of stolen children from Nithari before it begins to shut off the idiot box. No, we, the people, want to be left in peace with our conscience after a point. Sometimes after a hard day we would just like to watch the scandal of one starlet or another instead of being reminded that we live in a society where justice is sometimes the privilege of the few; complaisance is comfortable. When the spotlight shines heavily on a natural disaster or on an infraction of our basic principles of fairness we are moved in the moment and we react in the moment—preferably by an SMS or by signing an e-mail petition. Don't we lack the slow plodding methodical will needed to truly redefine our priorities as a nation so that the system itself changes? In fact this is the quality that a social activist or an organisation dedicated to a cause has that the collective still fails to manifest. It can be argued that social consciousness, if it is to have meaning as a term, should be about the collective power of individuals as opposed to the power of leadership of a great mind or the well-oiled efficiency of an organisation.

There is a notion that applies to individual mental health that might serve as a prism for examining the collective health of a nation. In the worst of cases, mental health professionals aim to improve a fractured individual's consciousness and continuity by repeating events and therapeutic actions that generate a short-term sense of well-being. They hope that these brief moments stacked on top of one another will eventually accumulate and create an awareness that lasts in the long-term. Maybe the collective consciousness is no different; it is after all fractured by our individual desires, the vested interest of various groups and the contra-

dictions inherent in a plural society with diverse communities. Social consciousness then can be seen as an aggregate of discrete moments of high social awareness that are not necessarily linked to each other but which, we can hope, will accrete over time and over separate campaigns for social justice to result in generating a new fabric for collective action. In other words, moments of social consciousness, ranging from the profound to the less so, like the Jessica Lall campaign, the gay rights judgment, the Aman Kachroo ragging case, while themselves singular events will eventually stack up towards building a nation where the citizens begin to believe they can effect difference.

Consciousness in the brain, at a neurological level, is both a puzzle and a marvel. Disparate sense organs and their sporadic inputs are able to generate a sense of holistic existence for the creatures that possess consciousness; in higher animals feelings of control and agency accompany it. A collective brain must, in the very least, possess similar properties. For social consciousness to exist the input from multiple partners must be taken into account from which a common course of action emerges. The whole in this system is always greater than the sum of its parts. The parts in this system feel they are of the whole. We have yet to go some distance before we arrive at this point but our bursts of action are the foundation stone for building an engaged society. Each time we overcome our indifference, our fatigue, our cynicism, we lay down one more brick.

The writer has written four novels including Babyji and Family Values.

